

CONGRESSIONAL LEADERSHIP FUND



TO: Friends and Allies
FROM: Dan Conston, President, Congressional Leadership Fund
DATE: November 15, 2024
RE: Eleven Key Takeaways from CLF

We are proud to have secured a House Majority again, defying months of confident media predictions that the House would flip to Democrats. We did what many said we could not do. We faced a tumultuous cycle, an onslaught of Democrat money designed to prevent a GOP trifecta, three times as many Biden-won districts to defend as Trump-won seats to contest, and redistricting maps that favor Democrats. We won five key Democrat-held seats, the magic number that I said was needed in my final pre-election donor memo, and our strongest incumbents won, with many overperforming their ticket. These are Members well-equipped heading into 2026.

President-Elect Trump's strong performance was a clear boon, keeping Biden-held seats winnable and making Trump-won districts attainable. Yet, in a reality check about the redistricting maps for this decade, despite Trump's performance and House Republicans leading the popular vote by 3.3% – the most in a presidential year since 1928 – we will have a 3-5 seat majority.

I am grateful for the investors who believed in our track record, our brand, and that we could hold the House. We could not have picked up seats in '20, won the Majority in '22, or held the Majority in '24 without you. We've raised \$871 million in my six years leading CLF and AAN – that is thanks to a multitude of patriotic Americans stepping into the breach and digging incredibly deep.

Speaker Mike Johnson took over a fractured conference at a difficult time, yet he turned countless skeptics into believers through work ethic, substance, charm, and ultimately results. I now often hear from donors that they are "Mike Johnson Republicans" – a sentiment I did not hear nine months ago. I would be remiss if I didn't note former Speaker McCarthy's significant contributions to our growth. In his five years as Leader and Speaker, CLF grew to a different stratosphere.

Eleven Key Takeaways from CLF:

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| 1. We Won the Largest Spending Races | 7. The Map Was Small & Favored Dems |
| 2. CLF Carried the Spending Load | 8. We Spent Where We Needed To |
| 3. Candidate Quality Matters | 9. Our Buying Was Effective and Efficient |
| 4. Ignored Dems' Bluff & Won On Defense | 10. Two Unsung Hero Programs |
| 5. Third-Party Candidates Cost Us | 11. Our Creative Was Unique, Impactful, and Persuasive |
| 6. We Drove Down Dems' Image | |

1. We Had a Winning Record, and We Won Overwhelmingly In Our Largest Spending Races

	Win	Loss	Outstanding
CLF Overall Spend	20	15	2
CLF 15 Biggest Spends	11	3	1

CLF's final record was 20-15, with two outstanding. In our 15 biggest spending races, we went 11-3, with one outstanding. **Those 15 biggest spending races were close, hard-fought races, illustrating that when we can narrow the overall spending gap, we win.**

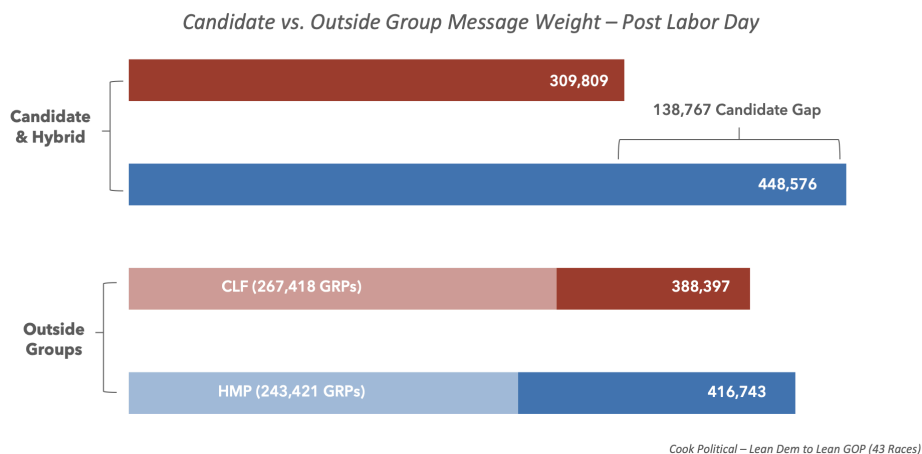
2. CLF Shouldered the Vast Majority of Republican Spending to Counter the Significant Advantages Held by Democrat Candidates

In the 20 highest-spending races nationwide, we provided on average over 50% of the GOP's broadcast TV presence despite candidates benefiting from significantly lower ad rates. In one key offensive win in Pennsylvania's 7th district, we represented 72% of the GOP's share of voice. Meanwhile, the Democrats' super PAC, House Majority PAC, spent similar money overall, but held a much lower overall share of voice because of Democrat candidate dollars.

On the hard-dollar side, Democrat candidates in key races held a 138,767 GRP advantage on TV. The NRCC strategically invested in hybrid ads with candidates (paid at the candidate TV rate). Without this move, the gap would have been much larger.

With strong support from the NRCC and JFCs from Speaker Johnson, Leader Scalise, and Whip Emmer, **fundraising was strong among GOP incumbents in key races, where they raised an average of \$5.7 million.** Democrat challengers raised \$5.9 million, roughly parity. However, Republican challengers were at a major disadvantage. The average Democrat incumbent raised \$6 million versus \$2.4 million for the average Republican challenger – **\$3.6 million less.**

CD	CLF Share of GOP Voice	HMP Share of Dem Voice
MI-07	55%	32%
NY-19	41%	24%
CA-45	58%	57%
NC-01	57%	42%
PA-07	72%	45%
AK-01	52%	38%
CA-13	45%	35%
ME-02	30%	36%
CA-27	55%	38%
CO-08	52%	34%
AZ-01	61%	36%
OR-05	47%	16%
NY-17	68%	35%
NY-04	53%	45%
WA-03	0%	25%
CA-22	46%	35%
PA-08	50%	28%
AZ-06	45%	17%
NE-02	36%	24%
CA-41	41%	20%



3. Candidate Quality Matters – Republican Stars Delivered

The Biden-district incumbents who won burnished their brands, worked their districts, and raised significant funds. They defended their images in a way only candidates can. We do not yet know presidential results by all districts, but many outperformed the GOP ticket.

- **Brian Fitzpatrick and Young Kim:** Despite holding highly competitive districts, Democrats didn't spend a single dollar against either of them due to the strength of their individual brands.
- **Jen Kiggans** kept her race at bay.
- **Mike Lawler and Tom Kean** outperformed the GOP ticket, overcoming \$9.4 million spent against them in the final two weeks alone.
- **John James** easily beat back \$12 million spent against him.

Five strong GOP candidates flipped seats with disciplined campaigns:

- Three of the five were former state representatives or senators with strong bases and brands.
- Of the candidates who did not, they had credibility. Rob Bresnahan ran a prominent local business, which was important in establishing an alternative to white whale Matt Cartwright.

4. Democrats Spent Heavily in 2020 Trump-won GOP-held Seats. Despite Pressure, We Called Their Bluff, Spent Less, and Still Won Every Seat.

Democrats spent \$26.5 Million in nine GOP-held seats that Trump carried by 1% or more in 2020. We only invested in six and spent \$15.8 million, keeping precious resources focused on the most important toss-up races. We won every one of these nine races. Our biggest spend here, Mariannette Miller-Meeks, proved important, as she will win by around 800 votes.

5. We Drove Down Democrat Images Dramatically

CLF's succinct advertising took a heavy toll on Democrat images and dramatically raised their unfavorable ratings, even forcing many candidates and outside groups to waste precious time responding directly to our ads. For example:

- In NY-17, our [15 ads with clips of AOC praising Mondaire Jones](#) quickly raised Jones' rating as an "AOC-type Democrat" from 26% to 40%.
- In IA-03, we highlighted Bacaam's past as a shady Biden political operative and raised his unfavorable rating by 26%.
- In MI-10, Carl Marlinga's "[pedophile protector](#)" tag stuck - moving his unfavorable rating by 21 points.

The chart below shows other extreme examples and the effectiveness of our advertising in changing voters' perceptions of Democrats who were once thought untouchable.

District	Pre-Spending Dem Unfav	Most Recent Dem Unfav	Unfav Change
IA-03	3	29	-26
VA-02	11	33	-22
MI-10	12	33	-21
CA-27	15	33	-18
MI-07	4	22	-18
NJ-07	10	27	-17
NY-19	25	42	-17
NY-22	25	41	-16
AK-AL	28	43	-15
AZ-01	14	29	-15
CA-45	16	31	-15
NE-02	26	40	-14
WI-03	13	27	-14
NY-17	23	36	-13
OH-09	33	46	-13

6. We Moved Two Democrat Incumbents and a Democrat Challenger to Where We Needed Them, Only for Third-party Candidates to Cost Us Seats.

- In Ohio's 9th District, Marcy Kaptur beat Derek Merrin by 1% (1,193 votes) with a libertarian taking 4% (15,000 votes). Kaptur, a longtime incumbent, was more unfavorable than favorable in our final survey, and on Election Day, she reached only 48% of the vote – enough to lose.

- In North Carolina's 1st District, Democrat Don Davis won by 1.5%, while a libertarian took 2.5% from Republican Laurie Buckhout.
- In Oregon's 5th district, Janelle Bynum was driven down to 47.8% of the vote and both Bynum and Democrat outside groups were specifically responding to CLF ads in the final weeks. Yet a libertarian took 4.6% of the vote, while Rep. Chavez-DeRemer lost by under 3%.

7. We Knew the Map Was Small. Redistricting Maps This Decade Slightly Favor Democrats.

We said at the start of the cycle that the number of swing seats had decreased. This is due in large part to redistricting sweeping away most competitive districts. As votes have come in, the maps now slightly favor Democrats. This is best illustrated by the fact that House Republicans currently lead the popular vote by 3.3% – the best GOP House margin in a presidential year since 1928, per CNN – yet we'll have a 3-5 seat majority. For comparison, in 2014, the overall House margin was 5.7%, and Republicans won 247 seats. In 2020, House Republicans lost the popular vote by 3.1% and had 213 seats.

8. We Did Not Buy Blowouts. While There Are Close Races We Came Up Short and Wish We Spent More, It Could Not Have Come from Existing Major Spends.

Of the 20 races that have been called and we won, our average margin is 3.6%. The largest margin win? In CA-22, a Biden +13 seat, David Valadao won by only 10,000 votes, which due to low turnout translated to a 7% margin. Ironically, most of our biggest margin wins were in heavy Biden-won districts. We understood the map, spent where we needed to, and our investments were difference-making in key toss-up races.

9. Streaming & Buying: We Needed to Be Effective & Efficient

Given the overall spending disadvantage, we had to be strategic with our resources. Our success was found in:

- **Enhanced Streaming:** We significantly increased our streaming budget to \$37 million and found that heavy broadcast and streaming together were required to break through – far more than prior cycles.
- **Focus on Premium Inventory:** Prioritized higher visibility and better-quality ad slots (e.g., live sports) over adding more ad volume.
- **Shift to 15-Second Ads:** Moving to 15-second ads gave us twice the advertising frequency in crowded markets – at the same price. In LA, we moved 45% of our buy to 15-second ads and boosted our GRPs from 11,107 to 16,222 in LA for the same amount of money. This shift in LA, NY, and Detroit alone saved us \$29 million.

10. Two Unsung Hero Programs That Made a Difference

- **IE Digital Fundraising Program:** CLF's IE Digital Fundraising Program spent digital resources encouraging small-dollar donors to give to key candidates. Candidates and Members raised \$4 million hard dollars in the most important races nationwide. This program has grown steadily over three election cycles.
- **Voter Turnout and Ballot Chase:** In 30 districts, we invested heavily in voter turnout and absentee/early voting efforts, mobilizing the voters we needed to secure victories in our most pivotal races.

11. The Eye-Test: Our Creative Was Unique, Impactful, Persuasive

Some key examples of our advertising on page five:

PA-08 – Credible Local Voices to Break A Brand



NE-02 – Creatively Reinforce Consistent Message



CO-08 – Humanizing Impact of the Border Crisis



MI-07 – Defining in a Cluttered Market



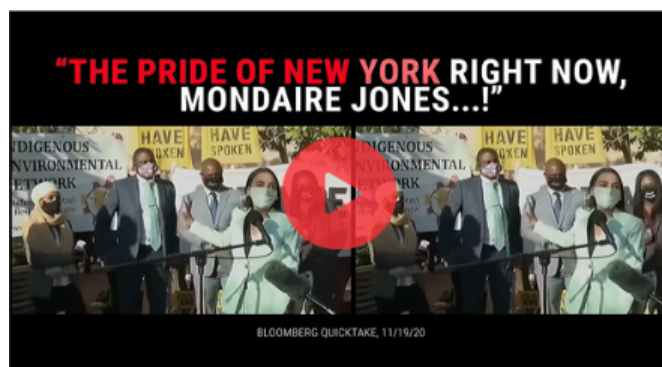
CA-41 – Turning Best Dem Recruit into Newsom 2.0



PA-07 – The Death Knell for Susan Wild's Brand



NY-17 – Defining Mondaire Jones, an AOC Radical



AK-AL - Utilizing Authentic Alaska Voices

